



Cover photo from the original story

A Mother's Dream for Energy Independence

Energy Independence and a Brighter Future for the Next Generation

By UNDP Sri Lanka · February 9th, 2026

28-year-old Lajith Dansi and her husband, Sithravel Lajith, have built a life rooted in resilience in the rural town of Puthukuduyirippu, Mullaitivu, in Sri Lanka.

Having lived through the war and its aftermath, Dansi recalls the times when even food and water were scarce. Today, while challenges remain, a quiet revolution is taking place in their home - powered by renewable energy.

Married in 2016, Dansi and Lajith now juggle the responsibilities of raising three young children, including their newborn baby, while maintaining a small home garden and rearing poultry. Lajith, a daily wage palmyrah tapper, works seasonally, leaving the family's finances vulnerable to weather and market conditions.

For years, cooking meant long hours spent gathering firewood, a time-consuming task that left little room for tending to crops or family. But everything changed in January 2025, when Dansi's family was selected through the UNDP Climate Promise Initiative, funded by the Japanese Supplementary Budget (JSB), to receive a mini-biogas plant.

"I had always been curious about biogas," Dansi shares, recalling how she first learned about the technology through social media. When the opportunity arose through the District Secretariat, she didn't hesitate.

Within just three weeks of installation, she was seeing results - cooking daily meals for her family for about two hours each day, with extra time for tea breaks and snacks.

“Before, cooking took so much time - just collecting firewood was exhausting. Now I can use that time in my garden and with my children”

The benefits didn't stop at energy. The biogas plant produces a rich liquid fertilizer, helping Dansi transition her home garden to fully organic methods. Previously, she spent nearly Rs. 5,000 a week on fertilizers and pesticides. Today, she hasn't needed to buy any chemical inputs since switching to organic liquid fertilizer.

Their flourishing garden grows a vibrant variety: long beans, okra, brinjals, curry chillies, spinach, papaya, watermelon, pumpkin, and pulses like black gram and green gram. Crop rotation and mixed farming methods now help them make the most of their land while protecting it from seasonal floods - aided further by a sprinkler irrigation system they received through a Citi-funded initiative.

“Our pest attacks have reduced. We are testing the organic methods, and so far, it's very encouraging,” Dansi smiles.

Despite still struggling to find fair market prices for their surplus produce, Dansi and her husband now make about Rs. 20,000 in profits. Every rupee saved through the biogas plant - on firewood, gas, fertilizer, and healthcare - is invested back into their family's future, helping them slowly repay their housing loan and plan for a better tomorrow.

In addition to the biogas system, Dansi's household also received poultry coops and chicks and will soon benefit from solar panels. These integrated renewable energy and agricultural supports offer an inspiring model for sustainable rural development.

Even during her pregnancies, Dansi worked tirelessly in the fields.

“I want to show my children that hard work, combined with opportunity, can change our lives,” she says.

The journey from hardship to hope continues for Dansi's family. Thanks to the renewable energy technologies introduced by UNDP's Climate Promise Initiative, every sunrise brings a little more energy, a little more savings - and a lot more hope for the future.

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